

THE SOMATIC RESET SERIES

Nervous System Healing for Burnout

Rewire Your Body After Chronic Stress

Disclaimer

This book is intended for educational and informational purposes only. It is not a substitute for professional medical, psychological, or psychiatric advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Always consult a qualified healthcare provider before making changes to your health routine, especially if you have a pre-existing condition.

The practices described here are general wellness approaches. Results will vary between individuals. The author and publisher accept no liability for outcomes arising from use of this material.

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What Burnout Actually Is

Burnout is not a mindset problem. It's a physiological one. The word has been so overused that it now carries a vague association with being very tired from work. But clinical burnout is a specific state of nervous system collapse — and understanding it accurately is the first step toward genuine recovery.

The Three Phases of Burnout

Burnout typically progresses through recognisable stages. In the first phase, there's high activation and drive — working intensely, feeling capable, perhaps even thriving on the pressure. The nervous system is running on sympathetic activation, cortisol is elevated, and the productivity feels sustainable because it's producing results.

The second phase is the erosion phase. The system can no longer sustain the output it was producing. Sleep becomes less restorative. Motivation fluctuates. There are more bad days than good. Emotions are less regulated. This phase is often when people push harder, interpreting the decline as a personal failing rather than a physiological signal.

The third phase is collapse. The nervous system cannot sustain even basic function. Getting out of bed feels effortful. Concentration is severely impaired. Emotional responses are either blunted or disproportionate. Physical symptoms — frequent illness, chronic pain, digestive disruption, heart palpitations — become prominent. This is dorsal vagal shutdown, as described in the first book in this series. The system has exhausted its capacity for sympathetic activation and has moved into conservation mode.

Why Conventional Recovery Advice Fails

The standard advice for burnout — take a holiday, get more sleep, practice self-care — is not wrong, but it's insufficient for the third phase. The nervous system in collapse doesn't recover from a week off. It requires systematic rehabilitation, in the same way that a physically injured body requires specific rehabilitation rather than just rest.

The mistake is treating burnout as if it's simply accumulated fatigue that needs rest to resolve. In reality, the nervous system has undergone adaptive changes — altered cortisol rhythms, down-regulated sympathetic responsiveness, impaired prefrontal function — that don't reverse without deliberate intervention.

"Burnout is not the consequence of caring too much. It's what happens when a body runs empty and keeps being asked to produce."

The Recovery Sequence

Recovery from burnout follows a sequence. Attempting to skip phases — going straight from collapse to productivity — reliably produces relapse. Understanding the sequence saves time.

Phase One: Safety and Stabilisation

The first phase of recovery is about creating physiological safety. Not psychological reassurance — actual biological safety signals sent to the nervous system through consistent, predictable daily rhythms. Regular sleep and wake times. Regular meals. Minimal over-stimulation. Very gentle movement.

This phase feels slow and often unsatisfying because it doesn't produce visible results. You're not building strength or productivity. You're rebuilding the foundation. The analogy of a cracked structural wall is useful: you can paint over it, but the crack will return unless the foundation is repaired first.

Breathwork is the most accessible tool in this phase. The extended exhale breathing and coherent breathing from earlier books in this series are appropriate. Avoid high-intensity exercise, significant dietary changes, or any practice that adds physiological demand. The

system is in triage. Give it conditions, not challenges.

Phase Two: Gentle Reactivation

Once some stability has returned — sleep is somewhat consistent, acute physical symptoms are reducing, there are more functional hours in the day — it's appropriate to begin gentle reactivation of the system. This might look like short walks, light mobility work, brief social contact, small creative projects with no stakes attached.

The critical instruction in this phase is pacing. Burnout recovery has a characteristic pattern of boom-and-bust: a good day leads to overactivity, which leads to a crash, which leads to frustration, which leads to another push. Breaking this cycle requires deliberately doing less than you feel capable of on good days — banking the capacity rather than spending it immediately.

Phase Three: Rebuilding Capacity

Phase three is where genuine rebuilding happens. Gradually increasing exercise intensity, returning to work or meaningful activity in measured doses, reintroducing challenge without recreating the conditions that led to collapse.

The questions worth sitting with at this phase: What in the original environment produced the burnout? What

structural changes — to workload, schedule, relationships, expectations — would make a recurrence less likely? Burnout recovery without environmental change produces burnout recurrence. The nervous system cannot heal in the same conditions that injured it.

"Recovery is not weakness. Pacing is not giving up. Rebuilding slowly is the only way to rebuild that lasts."

The Burnout Body — Specific Somatic Work

Burnout has a characteristic body signature. This chapter addresses that specific physical territory.

The Collapsed Posture

Burnout produces a recognisable posture: shoulders forward, head dropped, spine curved, chest compressed. This is the dorsal vagal posture — the physical expression of shutdown. It both reflects and reinforces the underlying state.

Gentle postural work — not aggressive correction, but deliberate expansion — sends opposite signals. Wall angels: stand with your back against a wall, feet slightly away, and slowly raise and lower your arms in a snow-angel motion, maintaining contact with the wall throughout. Two sets of ten, done slowly. The opening of the chest and upper back activates different proprioceptive signals than the collapsed posture.

Fatigue vs. Rest Deficits

An important distinction in burnout recovery: there are different types of rest. Physical rest (sleep, lying down)

addresses physical fatigue. Mental rest addresses cognitive overload. Sensory rest addresses overstimulation. Emotional rest addresses the exhaustion of managing others' emotions. Creative rest addresses depletion of imagination and generativity.

Most burnout sufferers have deficits in multiple types simultaneously. A holiday that involves managing family dynamics, constant social stimulation, and a packed schedule addresses physical rest but deepens emotional and sensory deficits. Genuine recovery requires identifying which rest types are most depleted and addressing those specifically.

Body-Based Practices for Burnout Recovery

Restorative yoga — specifically postures held for three to five minutes with full support from props (blankets, bolsters) — activates the parasympathetic system without requiring physical effort. Legs-up-the-wall pose (viparita karani) is the single most frequently recommended posture by somatic therapists for burnout: lie on your back and rest your legs up against a wall for five to fifteen minutes. The mild inversion calms the nervous system and reduces cortisol measurably.

Weighted blankets or firm physical pressure (a hand pressed firmly on the sternum, or the forehead pressed

lightly against a surface) activates deep pressure receptors that have a reliably calming effect on the autonomic nervous system. This is the same mechanism as therapeutic touch and weighted therapy blankets used in occupational therapy.

"The body that burned out needs a fundamentally different relationship with effort. Not less effort forever — just a different starting point."

What Sustainable Looks Like

Recovery from burnout is an opportunity most people don't fully use. This chapter is about using it.

Redesigning the Conditions

Recovery without change is preparation for recurrence. The nervous system that burned out did so in a specific context — a specific job structure, relational dynamic, sleep pattern, workload expectation, or combination of these. Before returning to full function, it's worth conducting a clear-eyed inventory of which conditions contributed most to the burnout and which of them can actually change.

Some conditions are external and changeable: work hours, job role, physical environment, commute. Some are internal and changeable with work: perfectionism, difficulty delegating, inability to say no, chronic over-responsibility. Some may not be changeable in the short term. Understanding the difference allows for realistic planning rather than either passivity or futile effort.

Early Warning System

Most people, in retrospect, can identify signs that were present six to twelve months before they fully burned out. The challenge is that those signs are easy to dismiss when you're in the middle of a busy life. Building a personal early warning system — a set of two or three specific, observable indicators that signal your system is under unmanageable pressure — creates the opportunity to intervene earlier next time.

Early warning signs tend to be individual. For some people it's sleep: three nights of poor sleep in a row is a signal. For others it's social withdrawal: cancelling plans without wanting to. For others it's physical: a specific kind of jaw tension, or recurring headaches. Know your signs. When they appear, treat them as information rather than inconvenience.

"The goal is not to become someone who doesn't burn out because they feel less. It's to become someone who reads their body accurately enough to stop before collapse."
